



A P R O P O S A L F O R N O R T H E R N T R U S T

Reimagining the Public Digital Experience

Five distinguished design moves to modernize northerntrust.com and reassert leadership against JPMorgan Private Bank, Goldman Sachs, UBS and Morgan Stanley.

Prepared June 2026

THE CONTEXT

A 130-year heritage brand competing on a 2010-era website.

13×

JPMorgan Private Bank
organic traffic vs. NT

2.7/5

Northern Trust heuristic
score (Nielsen 10)

15

Feature gaps vs.
peer benchmark set

The brand still wins on heritage, AUM, and trust — but loses every digital first impression to peers who treat the website as a flagship product, not a brochure.

Five distinguished moves.

Each pillar is independently shippable, peer-validated, and measurable.

01

Audience-First Entry

Route HNW, Institutional and Asset Servicing users into purpose-built journeys from the homepage.

02

A Unified Visual System

One design language across every NT subdomain. Modern typography, restrained luxury palette.

03

Interactive Wealth Tools

Calculators, scenario planners and "Find an Advisor" as hero moments on the public site.

04

Editorial Insights Hub

A magazine-grade research destination that earns search traffic and demonstrates expertise.

05

Trust & Accessibility

WCAG 2.2 AA, performance budget, transparent trust signals — table stakes done beautifully.

PILLAR 01

Audience-First Entry Architecture

PEER BENCHMARK

JPMorgan Private Bank and UBS both segment from the homepage hero — JPM's organic traffic is roughly 13× Northern Trust's.

The problem today

A single generic homepage forces a \$1.6T institutional wealth manager, a HNW family, and an asset-servicing CFO to all funnel through the same hero. The value proposition reads as "everything for everyone" — which lands as "nothing for me."

Our proposal

- Three clearly labelled audience doorways above the fold: Personal Wealth · Institutional · Asset Servicing.
- Persistent audience context that re-skins navigation, featured insights and CTAs.
- Smart "Continue where you left off" affordance for returning visitors.
- Measurable: time-to-relevant-content and qualified lead form starts.



J P M P B

Reference pattern

PILLAR 02

A Unified, Modern Visual System

PEER BENCHMARK

Goldman Sachs Private Wealth and Morgan Stanley both run a single, disciplined visual system across every public surface.

The problem today

northerntrust.com, the asset-management subdomain and the wealth portal look like three different companies. Type, color, photography and component patterns drift across pages. The Asset Management landing page currently 404s — a brand-equity leak in plain sight.

Our proposal

- One design system: tokens for color, typography, spacing, motion — shared across every NT property.
- Restrained luxury palette: deep navy + ivory + a single gold accent. Retire the stock-photo blue gradients.
- Editorial serif display paired with a clean modern sans — own a typographic signature.
- Component library shipped in Figma + code, governed centrally.



PILLAR 03

Interactive Wealth Tools as Hero Moments

PEER BENCHMARK

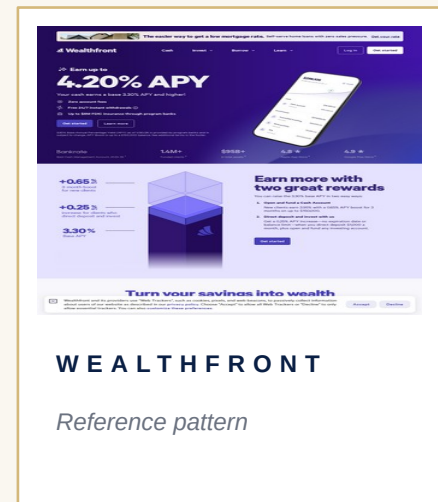
Wealthfront, Betterment and Morgan Stanley use interactive tools as their primary acquisition surface.

The problem today

NT's public site is almost entirely passive reading. Visitors cannot model a wealth-transfer scenario, see a sample portfolio view, or find an advisor without filling a contact form. Every modern peer treats interactivity as the proof of expertise.

Our proposal

- "Find an Advisor" with geo + specialty filters, surfaced in the primary nav.
- Wealth-planner and tax-scenario calculators as featured homepage tiles.
- Public preview of the client portal — three real screens, not a marketing video.
- AI-assisted "Ask Northern Trust" concierge for insights discovery.



PILLAR 04

Editorial-Grade Insights Hub

PEER BENCHMARK

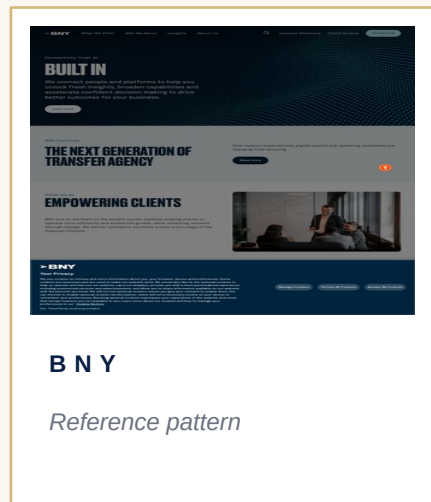
Goldman Sachs Insights demonstrates how a private bank can rank for, and own, an investment-thinking category.

The problem today

NT publishes genuinely strong research, then buries it in a flat list with no topic structure, no author identity and weak metadata. Goldman Sachs Insights and BlackRock's research hub each generate more organic visits to a single article than NT's entire insights section.

Our proposal

- Magazine-style hub: topic clusters (Markets · Tax · Legacy · ESG · Family Office).
- Author pages with credentials, portrait and a feed of their work.
- Long-form templates with pull quotes, charts, audio and 60-second summaries.
- Topic-cluster SEO architecture to close the 13x organic traffic gap.



BNY

Reference pattern

PILLAR 05

Trust & Accessibility by Design

PEER BENCHMARK

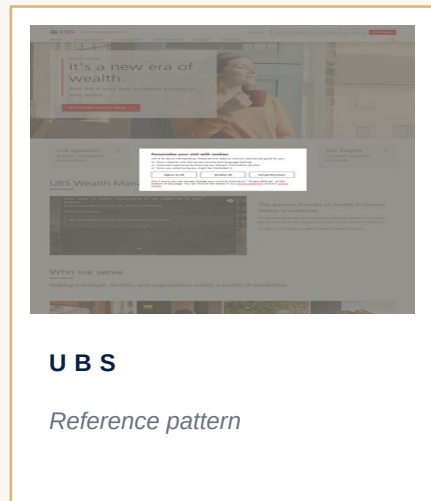
UBS publishes its accessibility statement and conformance roadmap publicly — a trust signal in itself.

The problem today

A wealth brand cannot afford accessibility debt, slow pages or vague trust signals. Today NT scores below peers on color contrast, keyboard focus, mobile performance and the legibility of regulatory / award badges. Trust is the product — the site should look the part.

Our proposal

- WCAG 2.2 AA as a hard baseline; published accessibility statement.
- Performance budget: LCP < 2.0s, CLS < 0.05, JS < 200KB per page.
- Prominent, designed trust panel: AUM, awards, regulatory, security.
- Inclusive photography commissioned for NT — no generic stock.



THE LANDSCAPE

Who Northern Trust is up against.



The screenshot shows the JPMorgan Private Bank homepage. It features a large, abstract background image with financial data overlays, including stock price changes like +0.28%, +0.22%, +8.89%, +8.66%, +8.47%, and +0.63/+25.00%. A section titled 'Profit power: Four stock sectors primed for growth' is visible. Below this, there's a 'Trending Topics' section with links to 'Investing in Emerging Markets' and 'ESG Investing'.

JPMorgan PB
Audience-routed homepage



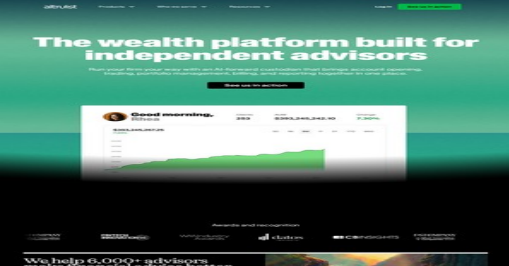
The screenshot shows the Goldman Sachs Private Wealth Management page. It features a headline: 'Goldman Sachs Private Wealth Management's strategies are intentionally designed for your unique needs and goals.' Below the headline, there are two images: one of a man in a suit and another of a globe.

Goldman Sachs
Editorial research hub



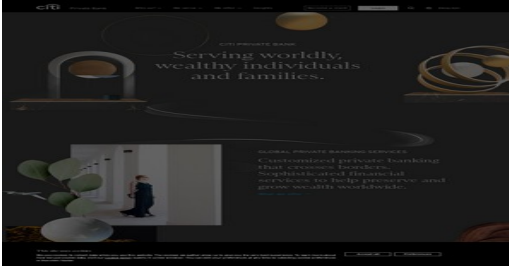
The screenshot shows the UBS Wealth Management page. It features a headline: 'It's a new era of wealth.' Below the headline, there's a section titled 'UBS Wealth Management' with a list of services and a 'Who we serve' section.

UBS
Global, accessible system



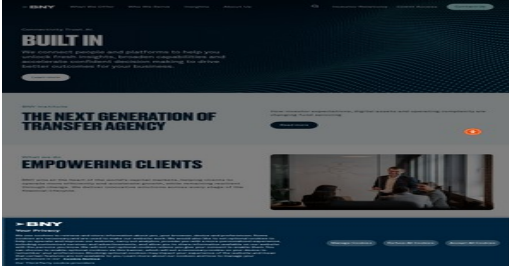
The screenshot shows the Morgan Stanley Wealth Management page. It features a headline: 'The wealth platform built for independent advisors.' Below the headline, there's a section titled 'Good morning, [Name]' with a personalized dashboard showing various financial metrics and a line graph.

Morgan Stanley
Interactive client tools



The screenshot shows the Citi Private page. It features a headline: 'Serving worldly, wealthy individuals and families.' Below the headline, there's a section titled 'Citi Private Bank' with a list of services and a 'Citi Private Bank' logo.

Citi Private
Tiered service tiers



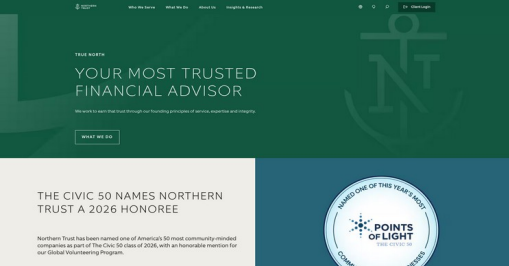
The screenshot shows the BNY page. It features a headline: 'BUILT IN' and 'THE NEXT GENERATION OF TRANSFER AGENCY'. Below the headline, there's a section titled 'EMPOWERING CLIENTS' with a list of services and a 'BNY' logo.

BNY
Institutional clarity



The screenshot shows the Wealthfront page. It features a headline: 'Earn up to 4.20% APY'. Below the headline, there's a section titled 'Earn more with two great rewards' with a list of rewards and a 'Turn your savings into wealth' section.

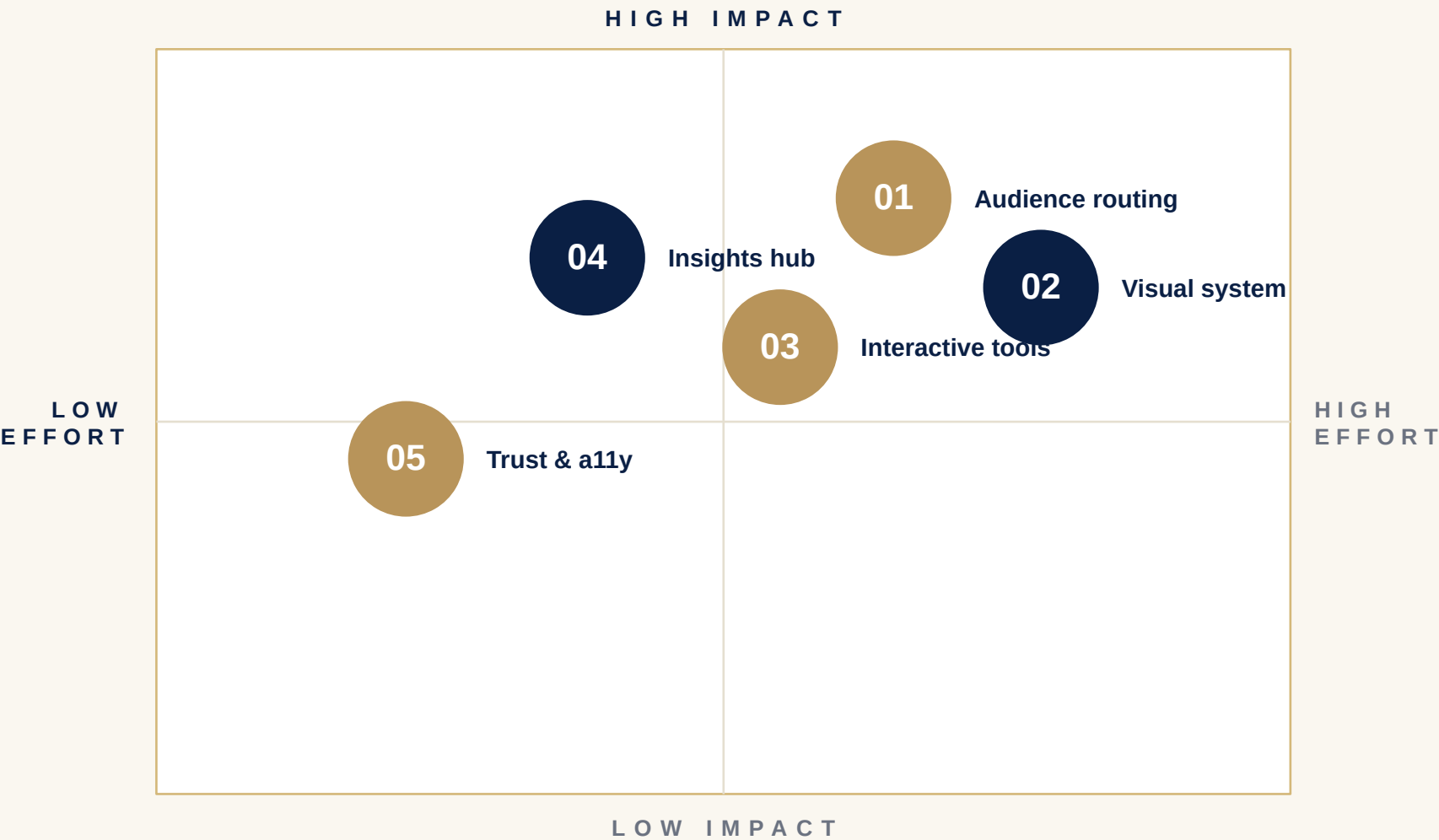
Wealthfront
Calculator-led acquisition



The screenshot shows the Northern Trust page. It features a headline: 'YOUR MOST TRUSTED FINANCIAL ADVISOR'. Below the headline, there's a section titled 'THE CIVIC 50 NAMES NORTHERN TRUST A 2026 HONOREE' and a 'POINTS OF LIGHT' logo.

Northern Trust
Today

Impact vs. effort.



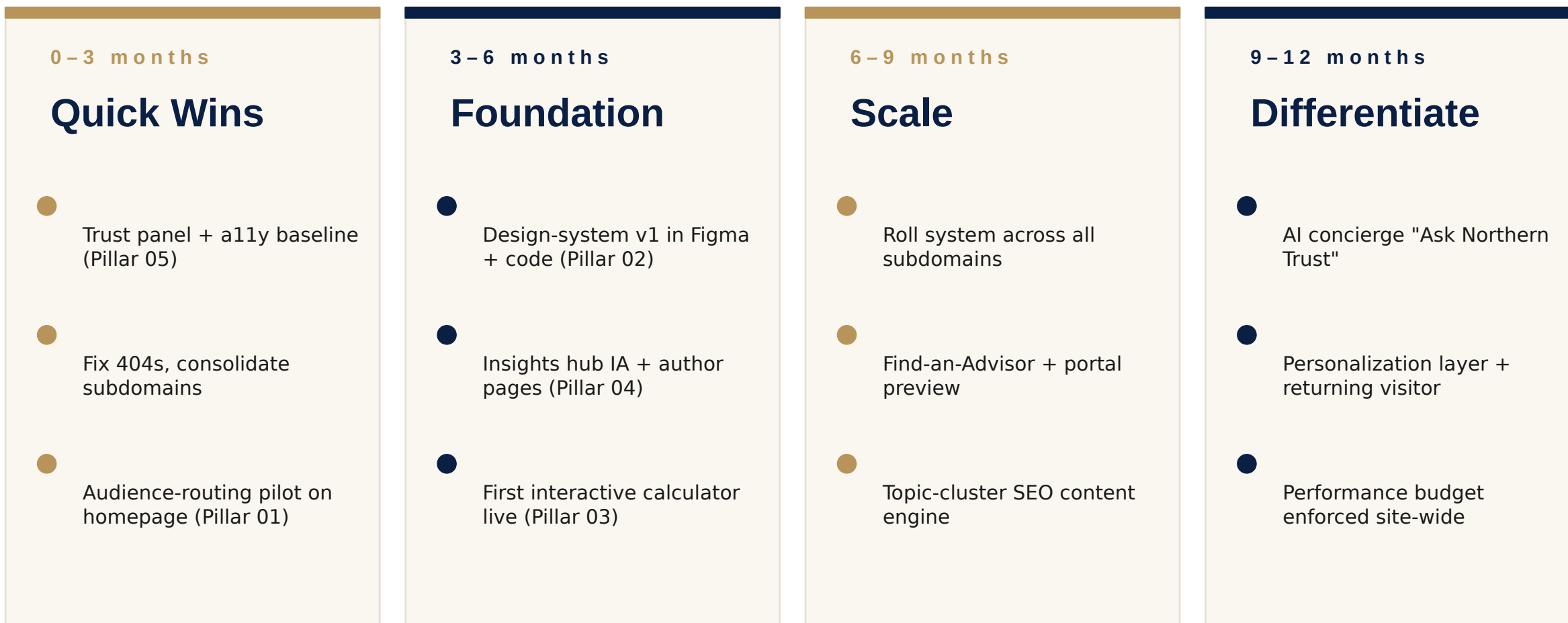
Reading the matrix

Top-left is the sweet spot: high business impact, achievable inside one quarter.

Pillar 05 (Trust & Accessibility) is a quick win and unblocks everything else.

Pillar 02 (Visual System) is the heaviest lift — but every other pillar compounds on it.

A phased twelve-month plan.



OUTCOMES

What success looks like in twelve months.

3x

qualified lead-form starts from the homepage

2.0s

LCP across the top 50 entry pages

+150%

organic traffic to insights, year on year

AA

WCAG 2.2 conformance, publicly stated

4.4/5

Nielsen heuristic re-score (from 2.7)

1

unified design system across all NT subdomains

The brief in one sentence.

"Northern Trust is the most trusted name in private wealth. The website should be the most trusted experience in private wealth — quietly confident, demonstrably expert, and unmistakably ours."

— The design principle we propose to anchor every decision.

Heritage is a moat. But heritage that does not feel modern reads as tired. The five pillars give Northern Trust a website that earns the brand back, one interaction at a time.

NEXT STEPS

Where we go from here.

- 1 Workshop**

Half-day alignment with NT brand, digital and wealth leadership to validate the five pillars.
- 2 Discovery sprint**

Two-week diagnostic: analytics deep-dive, stakeholder interviews, a11y audit, content inventory.
- 3 Pilot**

Ship Pillar 05 + an audience-routing pilot inside the first quarter — visible momentum, measurable lift.
- 4 Scale**

Quarterly releases against the twelve-month roadmap, governed by a joint NT × partner steering group.